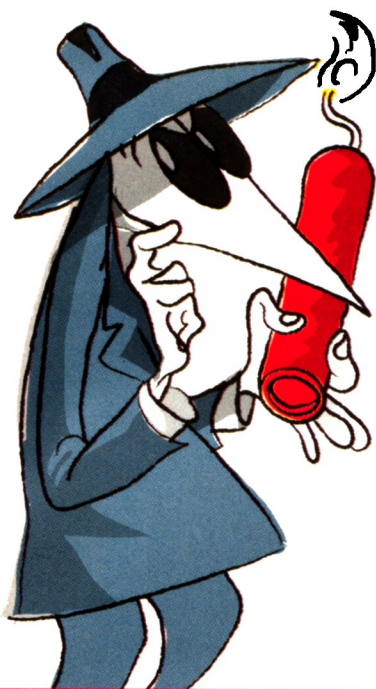




SAURABH SINGH

THE WAR WITHIN

R&AW was set up in 1968 with handpicked individuals. A permanent cadre, Research Analysis Service (RAS), was set up in 1986 with 200 officers where 30 per cent staff would be on deputation. Recruitment to RAS is drying up and R&AW is split between the two groups.

RAS CADRE

- 1 Hired into RAS, stay with the organisation until retirement.
- 2 Not susceptible to temptation. Majority of compromised agents belong to non-RAS cadre.
- 3 Lesser chances of leaving midstream. Motivation for area specialisation.

DEPUTATIONISTS

- 1 From other government services. Stay on indefinitely.
- 2 Do not undergo special military training. Learning one foreign language is not mandatory.
- 3 Leave the organisation at any point in their career. No incentive to superspecialise.

How R&AW hires its SPIES

- R&AW makes a presentation at the civil services academy. Recruits given option to join RAS after one year in parent service.
- After psychological test and interview, candidates are given

a three-year training course.

- At end of the fourth year they join R&AW as Under Secretaries.
- Deputationists join from government services like IPS and armed forces after a circular is sent out.

say a permanent cadre is vital because the agency has become a parking slot for mid-level officials from other organisations. "Deputationists leave after they gain expertise and this is a loss of knowledge in a specialised organisation. Our threats

have changed and the civil services can no longer provide the right people. We need to strengthen our permanent cadre," says former R&AW chief Vikram Sood.

One solution, say insiders, could be to scrap RAS and recruit candidates

who have put in three years of service in various civil services, akin to the IB's permanent secondment scheme. The Dulat Committee recommended permanent secondment during the agency's last major cadre review in 2005. However, IPS officers who come in on deputations never stay for long because they have better promotion prospects as career police officers.

When Kao carved the organisation out of the IB in 1968, he began it with individuals handpicked from all walks of life—the 'Kaoboy.' In 1986, this ad-hoc selection process was replaced by RAS and service rules were formalised but being a restricted service, recruitments were kept out of the purview of the UPSC. Seventy per cent of the cadre would be in-house while the remainder would be deputationists. R&AW officials were given the choice of returning to their parent cadre or being permanently absorbed into RAS. The new recruits were given specialised military training, taught spycraft, proficiency in one foreign language and began their tenure in border areas.

Over the years, RAS became less attractive and even so with 'permanent secondment' being institutionalised four years ago. Officials say the incentives to join the agency are simply inadequate. "This is the only service where the Government asks you to commit an illegal act, steal technology and recruit spies in foreign countries at great personal risk with no extra compensation," says former R&AW chief Anand Kumar Verma who advocates greater autonomy through an Act of Parliament to enable it to recruit the best from the open market. The agency needs to increase its pool of candidates to ensure a better intake. "R&AW should be brought under the purview of the UPSC through a separate examination and its inductees must be given the preliminary course at the civil services academy," suggests former R&AW official B. Raman. Clearly, unless R&AW resolves its cadre wars, the graveyards that its chief sees could be more than symbolic. ■